

September 27, 2026

Scientific Reports

Dear Dr. Yang,

This revised manuscript concerns *RankCloak Conceals the Surface Form of Synthetic Cryptographic Artifacts in Language Model Generated Text* (submission 0170c7b2-1065-4344-a5d5-b839b51ac22c).

The V4 revision addresses the editor's technical assessment and Reviewer 1's ten points while retaining Reviewer 2's acknowledgment and all original review wording. It adds complete token-filter documentation, six strict-gate failure analyses with exact text windows and matched comparators, bounded transport decomposition, a configuration compatibility check, source-based complexity analysis and a directional fixed-message quantization endpoint. The conceptual block, integrity, ECC and retransmission fallback is explicitly unimplemented.

The primary coherence evaluation now assesses complete messages in their authentic prompt context under a fixed rubric that allows minor awkwardness. Two blinded local model judges evaluate each item independently. The frozen sample contains 576 messages from 48 payloads, paired with ordinary output using matched greedy continuation. Complete ratings are available for 537 pairs. Panel acceptance is 90.3% for encoded messages and 96.6% for ordinary controls, with a paired difference of -6.3 [-8.7, -3.9] percentage points (95% payload-cluster interval). Supplementary Note S20 reports calibration mistakes, score distributions, disagreement, missing-score bounds and exact unfavorable examples. This completed automated evaluation provides evidence addressing Reviewer 1 comment 4.

The earlier fragment pilots and limited local-likelihood results remain in the supplement. The new study was designed after those results and frozen before its own scoring. Historical adverse findings are unchanged, including failed transmission conditions and zero recovery among 960 fixed Q4 messages decoded from saved Q8 ranks. RankCloak demonstrates surface-form concealment and configured inversion, without a confidentiality or indistinguishability guarantee.

The V4 code and data are available at <https://github.com/mantzaris/llm-rankcloak>. Published version 2.0.0, DOI <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22555497>, covers V3 only. A DOI-assigned deposit covering V4 remains outstanding.

Sincerely,

Alexander V. Mantzaris
School of Data, Mathematical, and Statistical Sciences
University of Central Florida
alexander.mantzaris@ucf.edu